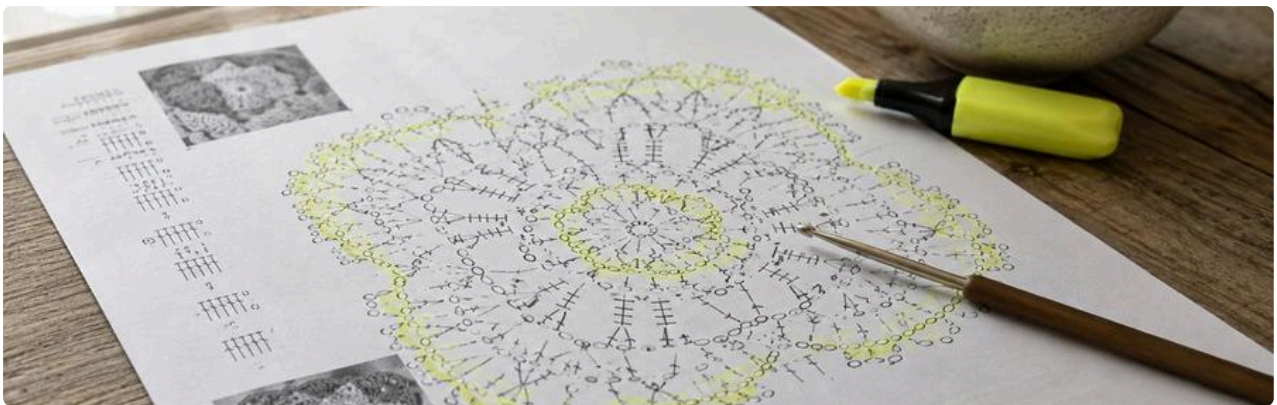


FUNDAMENTALS

How to Read a Crochet Pattern Without Panicking

Abbreviations, gauge, and repeats explained the way we wish someone had explained them to us.

Updated 2026 • 6 min read



Crochet patterns look like a foreign language the first time you open one: rows of abbreviations, asterisks, and numbers in brackets. Once you know what the shorthand means, though, a pattern is just a recipe — a repeated set of steps written as compactly as possible.

Common abbreviations

ABBREVIATION	MEANS
ch	Chain
sc	Single crochet
dc	Double crochet
hdc	Half double crochet
sl st	Slip stitch

st(s)	Stitch(es)
rep	Repeat
sk	Skip
inc / dec	Increase / decrease

What gauge actually means

Gauge tells you how many stitches and rows fit into a set square, usually 10cm/4in, when using the hook and yarn the pattern recommends. It exists because everyone's tension is slightly different — two people using the same hook and yarn can produce noticeably different-sized results.

For anything where exact size matters (garments, amigurumi with fitted parts), crochet a small gauge swatch first. For anything forgiving (scarves, blankets), you can usually skip it.

Reading repeats: asterisks and brackets

When you see something like:

```
*sc in next st, ch 1, skip 1 st; rep from * to end
```

Everything between the asterisks is one repeating unit. You work it over and over until you reach the end of the row, rather than the pattern spelling out the same instruction fifteen times.

Brackets work the same way but usually with a stated repeat count, like `[dc, ch 1]` `x4` — do the bracketed steps exactly four times.

Reading a stitch count

Most rows end with a number in parentheses, like `(12 sts)`. This tells you how many stitches you should have after finishing the row. Checking this every row —

not just at the end of a project — is the fastest way to catch a missed stitch before it compounds.

EB00K PICK

The Complete Crochet Stitch Dictionary

200+ stitches with charts — handy once you've got the abbreviations down.

[View on Amazon →](#)

Frequently asked questions

What does gauge mean in a crochet pattern?

Gauge tells you how many stitches and rows should fit into a set measurement, usually 10cm or 4 inches, when using the recommended hook and yarn. Matching it ensures your finished piece comes out the size the pattern intends.

What do the asterisks and brackets in a pattern mean?

Asterisks and brackets mark a section that repeats. Everything between the marks is worked as many times as stated, so you don't have to read the same instruction written out over and over.

Why doesn't my stitch count match the pattern?

The most common cause is a missed or extra stitch at the start or end of a row. Count your stitches at the end of every row while you're learning, rather than waiting until the end of the project to check.

Written by Emily Hartwell

Emily has been crocheting for over a decade, ever since her grandmother taught her the basics one summer. She started CrochetGuides to write the clear, honest, beginner-friendly instructions she wishes she'd had when she was learning — the ones that actually work the first time.